MOREH NEVUCHIM

Introduction to Moreh Nevuchim

Given Tuesday 24 March 2026 · Moreh Nevuchim

Sefer: מורה נבוכים / Moreh Nebuchim — The Guide for the Perplexed **Author:** רבינו משה בן מימון — Rambam (Maimonides) **This Class:** Background, biography, context, translations, controversies, and structure of the Moreh

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Context: Why Now?

- Over the past 4–5 years, Tuesday evenings have covered many aspects of the Rambam's writings:
- Sefer Madda, Hilchot De'ot, Hilchot Talmud Torah, Hilchot Teshuvah
- Letters: Iggeret HaShmad, letter on resurrection, letter to Rabbi Ovadyah the convert
- Introductions: to Mishneh Torah, to Pirkei Avot (Eight Chapters), to Perek Chelek (Sanhedrin)
- All of these trace back to one source: the Moreh Nevuchim
- The Moreh is where Rambam's philosophy and theology ultimately originates
- It's a daunting book — but it's time to deal with "the real stuff"
- Expected timeline: 2–3 years, going through systematically chapter by chapter

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Biography of the Rambam

Birth and Early Years

- Born **14th of Nisan**, either 1135 or 1138 (evidence now leans toward 1138)
- Born in **Cordoba, Spain**
- Father: **Rabbi Maimon ben Yosef** — a Dayan in Spain
- Rabbi Maimon was a student of the **Ri Migash** (Rabbi Yosef ibn Migash, 1077–1141, Seville)
- The Ri Migash was a student of the **Rif** (Rabbi Yitzchak Alfasi, 1013–1103, Algeria/Fez)
- Almost unbroken chain: **Rif → Ri Migash → Rabbi Maimon → Rambam**
- Rambam writes: "In very few places I disagreed with the Rif, because normally the Rif is always correct"
- Also exposed to philosophy from a young age — through the rise of the Islamic school of the **Mutakallimun**
- Mutakallimun = from the Arabic word "kalam" (the word / literalism)
- Developed in the 8th century → Greek works (Aristotle, medical texts) translated into Arabic
- Both Islamic and Jewish thinkers benefited from this

Leaving Cordoba (1148)

- Around age 10 (or 13) — family leaves Cordoba due to the **Almohad** persecution (Islamic Crusaders)
- Sojourned around the **Iberian Peninsula** for 12 years (1148–1160)
- Spent time in **Seville** — met a student of **Ibn Bajjah** (expert astronomer, quoted in the Moreh)
- Developed interests in astronomy and other disciplines during this period

Fez (1160–1165)

- Family moves to **Fez** for five years — father still alive
- Big question: why move to Fez where the Almohads were in control?
- Unclear whether he could live a full Jewish life there
- Wrote the famous **Iggeret HaShmad** (Essay on Forced Conversions) — in his early 20s
- Written with confidence and sarcasm
- Some suggest a hint that he himself lived a crypto life — Rav Shilat completely rejects this
- At age 23: begins writing his **Commentary on the Mishnah** (first major rabbinic work)
- Completes it seven years later in Egypt at age 30
- Already gaining a high reputation in his 20s

Israel (1165)

- In May 1165 — arrives in **Akko** with his father and brother David
- Stormy voyage — Rambam promised:
- Two days of fasting for the whole family
- One day of personal meditation and seclusion
- Travels from Akko → Yerushalayim → Hevron
- Spends approximately one year in Israel
- Then leaves for Egypt (reasons unclear — perhaps financial, perhaps too difficult)
- **Question from the shiur:** How can he live in Egypt? Torah says don't go back there!
- The **Radbaz** has a teshuvah with 3–4 answers on this

Egypt — Fustat (1166 onwards)

- Settles in **Fustat** (old Cairo) — approximately 4,000 Jews there at the time
- Spends the rest of his life here
- Brother **David** — the businessman of the family
- Traveled to India, Singapore, and other Far Eastern locations for trade
- **1177:** Shipwreck — David is lost at sea
- Rambam mourns deeply:

"If not for the Torah which is my delight, and for the scientific matters which let me forget my sorrow — I would have perished in my affliction" (יגעתי בעוני)

- Some suggest David had been financing Rambam → after his death, Rambam turned to practicing medicine
- Rabbi Avraham (Rambam's son) names his elder son **David** — most likely after this uncle

Major Works Written in Egypt

- **Mishneh Torah** — halakhic magnum opus, written in **Hebrew** (took 10 years)
- Written to be like a "replica of the Mishnah" — just as Rabbi Yehuda HaNasi wrote the Mishnah because Torah was being forgotten
- **Sefer HaMitzvot** — enumeration of 613 mitzvot, written in **Arabic**
- Many had tried before him — Rambam says they all got it wrong
- Includes 14 rules for how to properly enumerate the mitzvot
- Suggestion: read through Sefer HaMitzvot over the two days of Shavuot
- **Commentary on the Mishnah** — written in **Arabic**, translated by others into Hebrew
- **Medical works** — 10 books on medicine
- Most of Rambam's works are in **Arabic** — the Mishneh Torah is the notable exception (in Hebrew)

Court Physician

- Eventually becomes physician at the court of **Saladin** (Muslim ruler)
- Personal physician to Saladin's son **Al-Afdal**
- Had to commute from Fustat to the other side of Cairo daily
- Writes in a letter: "I barely have time to study — only on Shabbat"
- By the time he comes home in the evening → people waiting at his door for medical consultations

Death

- Dies **20th of Tevet, 1204**
- Buried in **Teveria** (Tiberias)

The Moreh Nevuchim — Background

When Was It Written?

- Began: **1185** — completed: **1191** (5–6 years)
- Rambam dies in 1204 → written in the last ~20 years of his life
- If born 1138 → he begins writing it around **age 47**
- Some ideas intended from much earlier:
- In his Commentary on Mishnah Sanhedrin (age ~23–30): mentions intending to write a book on prophecy → never writes a separate book → incorporates it into the Moreh
- Also mentions intending to write a book explaining the drashot of the Chachamim → decides against it ("if I explain too clearly it's not good; if I use more allegories, what's the point?")

Who Was It Written For?

- Primarily for his student: **Yosef ben Yehuda ibn Shimon**
- Had been studying under Rambam in Fustat
- Moved to Aleppo → Rambam decided to write this for him
- **But also intended for a wider audience:**

- Clear indications throughout that he wants philosophically trained people to read it
- In some places explicitly writes that certain ideas should reach the masses
- Example: the danger of believing in God's physicality → "teach this to the children, teach this to the women"

Purpose

- Navigate the conflict between **Aristotelian philosophy** and **Torah tradition**
- For the person who is both well-versed in science/philosophy AND in Torah
- Deals with: God's essence, unity, incorporeality, knowledge, revelation, prophecy, evil, mitzvot, providence, prayer

The Original Name

- Rambam writes in **Arabic** — does NOT call it "Moreh Nevuchim"
- Original Arabic name: **דלאלת אלחאירין — Dalalat al-Ha'irin**
- Meaning: "Direction for those who are confused / lacking direction / misled / trapped"

Translations

Shmuel ibn Tibbon (1165–1232)

- Translates from Arabic to **Hebrew**
- Completed the translation in **1204** — the year of Rambam's death
- Rambam writes to him in **1199**: don't translate word for word
- "Good translators don't get stuck on word-for-word translation"
- Similar approach to Aryeh Kaplan (translator of Derech Hashem, the Living Torah Chumash, etc.)
- Despite this advice, some say ibn Tibbon was **too literal**
- Ibn Tibbon is the son of **Yehuda ibn Tibbon** — who translated:
- Emunot VeDeot (Saadia Gaon) from Arabic to Hebrew (the "Amar Yehuda" at the start of each essay)
- Chovot HaLevavot (Rabbeinu Bachya ibn Pakuda) from Arabic to Hebrew
- The ibn Tibbon dynasty made these Arabic works part of Hebrew literature — incredible contribution

The Name "Moreh Nevuchim"

- **Shmuel ibn Tibbon** coins the Hebrew name — not the Rambam
- The word **נבוכים** appears twice in Tanach:
- **Shemot 14:3** — Pharaoh says about Bnei Yisrael: כי נבוכים הם בארץ — "they are trapped/confused in the land"
- **Esther 3:15** — והעיר שושן נבוכה — "the city of Shushan was confused"
- In **both cases**: the confusion leads to the ultimate redemption (Yam Suf / Purim)
- Perhaps ibn Tibbon's message: this guide will lead the perplexed from confusion to clarity, just as nevuchim led to geulah

Yehuda Alcharizi (Toledo)

- Second translation — only 9 years after ibn Tibbon
- Felt ibn Tibbon was too literal → his translation was more free
- **Rabbi Avraham** (Rambam's son) preferred ibn Tibbon's translation
- Makes sense: Rambam and ibn Tibbon had been communicating directly
- Ibn Tibbon's version became the accepted one

Latin Translation (1224)

- Translated into Latin — now accessible to Christians (Dominicans, monks)
- This directly leads to controversy (see below)

Modern Translations

- **Rabbi Yosef Kapach** — great Yemenite leader, translated from Arabic to Hebrew
- **Dr. Michael Schwartz** — Israeli professor, more accessible modern Hebrew from Arabic
- **Friedlander** — translated from Arabic directly to **English** (red book: "The Guide for the Perplexed")
- Same Friedlander who translated Emunot VeDeot from Arabic to English

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Controversies Around the Moreh

During Rambam's Lifetime

- Not much controversy about the Moreh specifically during his life
- He completes it in 1191, dies in 1204 — doesn't have time to spread widely
- He DID have controversy about **resurrection** (techiyat hametim) → wrote Ma'amar Techiyat HaMetim

Controversy #1 — After His Death (Early 1200s)

- Already in Egypt: **Daniel HaBavli** challenges both the Mishneh Torah and the Moreh
- **Rabbi Avraham** (Rambam's son) writes **Milchamot Hashem** ("Wars of Hashem") — defending his father
- Issues included:
- Rambam's conception of **angels**
- His views on **prophecy** and **miracles**
- His statement that he would **reinterpret Bereishit** if Aristotle had proven the universe was eternal
- Controversy spreads to **Europe** — France, Provence

The Burning of 1232 (Montpellier)

- Agitators showed selections from the Latin translation to the **Dominicans**
- Selections were deemed heretical
- Public burning of the Moreh ordered in **Montpellier, 1232**
- A few years later: burning of the **Talmud** — whether connected, only Hashem knows
- The Jews would never have done this alone — it was under Dominican oversight

Controversy #2 — 1305

- Indirectly about the Rambam — not a direct attack on the Moreh
- Dispute between the **Rashba** and **Abba Mari**
- Issue: people were **misunderstanding** the Moreh → Rashba proposed a ban on studying philosophy under age 25
- Many disagreed → a major fight
- Not the Rambam's fault — but the Moreh was indirectly implicated

Later Critics

- **Rav Yaakov Emden** (1700s): wrote that the Moreh **cannot have been written by the Rambam**
- "The person who wrote the Mishneh Torah cannot be the same person who wrote this — it must be someone else"
- Too much "heresy" within it
- Still, even with critics in every generation → **Rambam won**
- Approximately **two-thirds of the Shulchan Aruch** follows the Rambam's rulings
- In philosophy: he is the most eminent Jewish philosopher

Structure of the Moreh

Introduction

- Written to his student Yosef ben Yehuda ibn Shimon
- To be studied after Pesach

Part One (70+ chapters)

Main theme: God — What God Is and Isn't

- Strong, elaborate rejection of **anthropomorphism**
- All literal physical descriptions of God in Tanach are to be reinterpreted
- This is the source for everything we've learned elsewhere (Madda, Sanhedrin, etc.)
- **Negative theology** — you cannot describe what God IS, only what God is NOT
- How can you talk about God being "compassionate" if He is infinite and indivisible?
- When we say Hashem is רחום → we mean He is "not not rachum"
- **Unity of God** — philosophical elaboration
- **Importance of intellect** in human perfection and understanding God
- Loosely corresponds to the **first five of the 13 Principles** (God exists, is one, has no body, is first, no idol worship)
- Though the fourth principle (God is first) is dealt with in Part Two

Part Two (50+ chapters)

Main theme: The Universe and God's Relationship with It

- **Is the world eternal?** — the major question

- Aristotle's dominant view: the universe is eternal (no beginning)
- Now vindicated by the Big Bang (Hubble 1929, confirmed in the 1960s) — but Rambam had to grapple with this head-on
- Rambam **rejects Aristotle's view** — not because the Torah says so, but because he believes it wasn't philosophically sound
- **Aristotelian cosmology** — the spheres having intelligence (complex topic)
- Conflict between **Bereishit** and Aristotelian/Platonic views of creation
- **Prophecy** — nature, levels, and mechanics of prophetic experience
- **Miracles** — what they are and how they operate
- **Angels** — conceived as forces of nature, not winged beings

Part Three (50+ chapters)

Main theme: Evil, Ethics, and Mitzvot

- **Why is there evil?** — categorized into three types
- **Hashgachah Pratit** (Divine Providence) — what it means, how it operates
- **Reasons for the Mitzvot** (Ta'amei HaMitzvot)
- Underlying theme in many mitzvot: **weaning us off Avodah Zarah** (idol worship)
- Prayer, ethics, and the purpose of human existence

Very Loosely — The Three Parts Map To:

Part	Focus	Question
Part One	God Himself	What is God? What is God not?
Part Two	God and the Universe	Did God create the world? How does He reveal Himself?
Part Three	God and Humanity	Why do we do what we do? Why is there evil?

Key Predecessors Referenced by the Rambam

Author	Work	Approximate Dates
Rav Saadia Gaon	Emunot VeDeot	Early 1000s
Rabbeinu Bachya ibn Pakuda	Chovot HaLevavot	Late 1000s / early 1100s (d. 1141)
Rabbi Avraham ibn Daud (Ra'avad)	Emunah Ramah	Mid-1100s

- Note: this is NOT the Ra'avad who wrote glosses on the Rambam — different person
- Rambam has read all of these, disagrees with some, and references them throughout

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Key Takeaways

1. The Moreh is the **source** of Rambam's philosophy — everything in Mishneh Torah, Commentary on the Mishnah, and the letters traces back here.
2. Written in **Arabic** (Dalalat al-Ha'irin) — the Hebrew name "Moreh Nevuchim" is from the translator ibn Tibbon, not from Rambam.
3. Written for his student Yosef ben Yehuda — but intended for a wider audience.
4. Purpose: **navigate the conflict** between Aristotelian philosophy and Torah tradition.
5. Three parts: God Himself → God and the Universe → God and Humanity.
6. Controversial from shortly after Rambam's death — but ultimately **Rambam won**.
7. A journey of 2–3 years ahead — brick by brick, chapter by chapter.

Next Class (After Pesach)

- The Rambam's own **Introduction** to the Moreh — his letter to his student before Part One begins.

Chag Pesach Kasher v'Sameach

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/fJhbJzySIgk · More shiurim: rabbikada.com